Optimization

4.3.3 Constraints in practice: penalize, reject or compare

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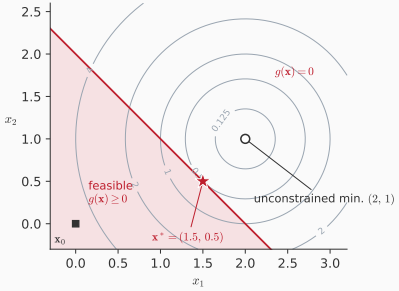
One problem, five treatments

$$\min\ f(\mathbf{x}) = (x_1-2)^2+(x_2-1)^2 \ \text{ s.t. } \ g(\mathbf{x}) = 2-x_1-x_2 \geq 0$$

- $\mathbf{x}^* = (1.5,\, 0.5)$, $f^* = 0.5$, $\lambda^* = 1$ (KKT, 4.2); the unconstrained minimum $(2,\, 1)$ is infeasible.
- Violation: $v(\mathbf{x}) = -\langle g(\mathbf{x})\rangle = \max\big(0, -g(\mathbf{x})\big)$, as in 4.3.1.

The same HJ of 1961 (3.2.5), from $\mathbf{x}^{(0)} = (0,\, 0)$, with the constraint communicated in five ways:

A ignore • **B** quadratic penalty • **C** exact penalty • **D** extreme barrier • **E** feasibility rule



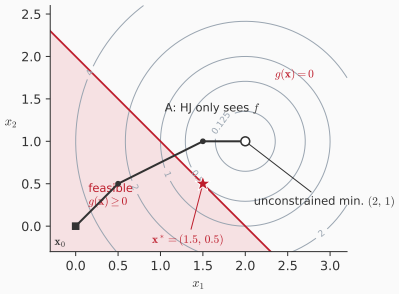
The problem is the same; only the way we communicate the constraints to the algorithm changes.

Does the algorithm know there is a constraint?

A — ignore. HJ receives only $F = f$ and returns

$$\mathbf{x} = (2,\ 1), \quad g = -1 : \ \text{infeasible} \quad (n_F = 96).$$

- HJ (and all of Ch. 3) minimizes the number we give it; it does not know what g is.
- The constraint only exists for it if it is in that number — or in the comparisons it makes.
- The algorithm stays unconstrained; feasibility is an outer layer.



n_F: calls to the function (or pair) that HJ receives;
$a = 2$, $P_0 = 0.5$, $T = 10^{-6}$ throughout the deck.

problem: f, g → constraint layer: A, B, C, D or E ↔ ($F(\mathbf{x})$ or "better?") Hooke–Jeeves (unconstrained)

Can we charge for the violation?

B — quadratic penalty, with fixed R:

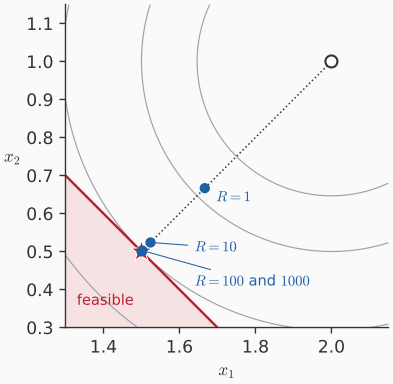
$$F_R(\mathbf{x}) = f(\mathbf{x}) + R\,\langle g(\mathbf{x})\rangle^2 = f(\mathbf{x}) + R\,v(\mathbf{x})^2.$$

$R > 0$ is chosen, not computed (not the HJ's R of 3.2.5).
On the infeasible side, $\nabla F_R = \mathbf{0}$ gives

$$\mathbf{x}_R = (2,\,1) - R\,v_R\,(1,\,1), \qquad v_R = \frac{1}{1+2R}.$$

- $v_R > 0$ for every finite R: always (slightly) infeasible.
- $\mathbf{x}_R \to \mathbf{x}^*$ from outside: it is the penalty of 4.3.1, but with fixed R and a single minimization.
- HJ finds these $\mathbf{x}_R$.

Paying for the violation does not forbid it.



How large should R be?

R	$\mathbf{x}_R$ (HJ)	$v(\mathbf{x}_R) = 1/(1+2R)$	$\|\mathbf{x}_R - \mathbf{x}^*\|$	n_F
1	(1.667, 0.667)	0.333	0.236	253
10	(1.524, 0.524)	0.048	0.034	244
100	(1.502, 0.502)	0.0050	0.0035	311
1000	(1.500, 0.500)	0.0005	0.00035	644

Small R

Cheap, but visibly infeasible: with $R = 1$, $v = 1/3$.

Large R

Almost feasible, but F_R has a narrow valley ($\kappa \sim R$, 4.3.1): HJ "crawls" — 644 calls.

The "right" R depends on the scale of g (4.3.1). The cure of 4.3.1 is an increasing R, with warm start; with fixed R, one chooses between infeasible and ill-conditioned.

Can we make the penalty exact?

C — exact penalty (ℓ_1): one pays v, not v^2:
$F_R = f + R\,v = f + R\,\big|\langle g \rangle\big|$.

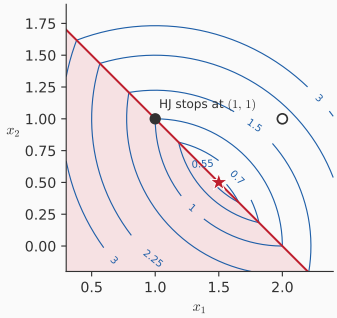
A local result

If $\mathbf{x}^*$ is a strict local minimizer and satisfies the KKT conditions with multipliers λ_j^*, then $\mathbf{x}^*$ is a local minimizer of $f + R\sum_j |\langle g_j \rangle|$ for every $R > \max_j \lambda_j^*$.

(Nocedal and Wright, 2006, Thm. 17.3)

Here $\lambda^* = 1$. HJ gives:

- $R = 0.5 < \lambda^*$: (1.75, 0.75), infeasible;
- $R = 1 = \lambda^*$ (outside the theorem): here it still gives $\mathbf{x}^* = (1.5, 0.5)$;
- $R = 2 > \lambda^*$: the minimizer of F_R is $\mathbf{x}^*$... but HJ stops at (1, 1).



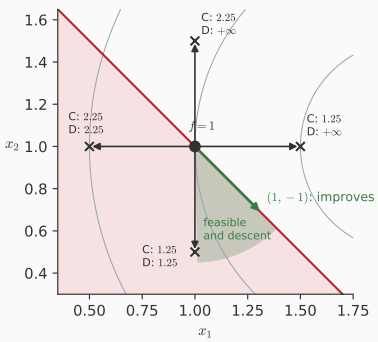
Level sets of F_2: a kink at $g = 0$.

The price: an upper bound on λ^* (unknown), and F_R is not differentiable where $\mathbf{x}^*$ lies. A local result, under assumptions — not universal.

Why did Hooke–Jeeves stop at $(1, 1)$?

At $(1, 1)$, $f = 1$. The trials $+P\mathbf{e}_1$, $+P\mathbf{e}_2$ leave X (C pays $R\,v$, D gives $+\infty$); $-P\mathbf{e}_1$, $-P\mathbf{e}_2$ stay in X, but f increases.

For any $P > 0$, no $\pm\mathbf{e}_j$ improves: in D, the directions that descend and stay feasible are the green wedge; in C, those that descend F_2 are the quadrant $d_1 > 0$, $d_2 < 0$. HJ halves P down to T and stops at a non-optimal point.



Fix: change the directions, not the method

The same HJ in $\mathbf{y}$, with $\mathbf{x} = Q\mathbf{y}$, $Q = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$: directions along and normal to the boundary. C ($R = 2$), D and E reach $\mathbf{x}^*$ ($n_F = 208$ in all three).

With linear constraints, the directions must follow the nearly active constraints (Lewis and Torczon, 2000).

What if we simply refuse infeasible points?

D — extreme barrier:

$$F(\mathbf{x}) = \begin{cases} f(\mathbf{x}), & g(\mathbf{x}) \geq 0, \\ +\infty, & g(\mathbf{x}) < 0 \quad (f \text{ is not evaluated}). \end{cases}$$

- No R, no scales: an infeasible point always loses; f is never evaluated outside X.
- Feasible iterates, provided $\mathbf{x}^{(0)} \in X$: from (3, 3) all is $+\infty$ and HJ stays put.
- From (0, 0): stops at (1, 1); $n_F = 91$, 45 of them outside X (f not evaluated).
- Not the log barrier (4.3.2): no wall, just a "no".

```
function y = ExtremeBarrier(f, g, x)
if any(g(x) < 0)
  y = Inf;            % f is not evaluated
else
  y = f(x);
end
end
```

This is what GLODS and DMS do

GLODS (5.1), MultiGLODS and DMS (6.5): $f = +\infty$ outside X: the objective function is not evaluated at infeasible points.

What if there is not even a $g(x)$?

Explicit constraint

We know g: whether and by how much it is violated. There is a v: B, C, E are possible. Constraint taxonomy for simulation-based optimization: Le Digabel and Wild (2023).

Hidden constraint

The simulator fails (`NaN`) without saying why or by how much. No v: of the strategies here, only D needs no violation measure.

```
function y = simulador(x)                          % black box
if x(1) + x(2) > 2, y = NaN;                         % "does not converge"
else, y = (x(1) - 2)^2 + (x(2) - 1)^2; end
end
F = @(x) ExtremeBarrier(@simulador, [], x);        % NaN -> Inf
x = HookeJeeves(F, [0 0], 2, 0.5, 1e-6, [], [], [], '1961');
```

Result: the same run as D — $(1, 1)$, $n_F = 91$ — without ever knowing g. The 45 failures also cost: the simulator ran until it failed.

Do we need to add objective and violation?

E — feasibility rule. HJ only needs to know which of two points is better. Compare the pair (v, f) — no new function:

1. feasible beats infeasible;
2. between feasible points, smaller f wins;
3. between infeasible points, smaller v wins.

This is Deb's rule (2000), used in NSGA-II (6.6).

- From (0, 0): same base points and same (1, 1) as D ($n_F = 91$).
- From (3, 3): D stays put; E reduces v and reaches (1, 1) ($n_F = 96$).
- Needs v: explicit constraints only (f is needed only when the v tie).

MATLAB

```
FE = @(x) [v(x), f(x)];            % the pair (v, f)
menor = @(a, b) a(1) < b(1) || ...
          (a(1) == b(1) && a(2) < b(2));
x = HookeJeeves(FE, [3 3], 2, 0.5, 1e-6, ...
                [], false, menor, '1961');
```

Python

```
FE = lambda x: (v(x), f(x))        # the pair (v, f)
menor = lambda a, b: a[0] < b[0] or \
          (a[0] == b[0] and a[1] < b[1])
r = hooke_jeeves(FE, [3, 3], 2, 0.5, 1e-6,
                 menor=menor, variante="1961")
```

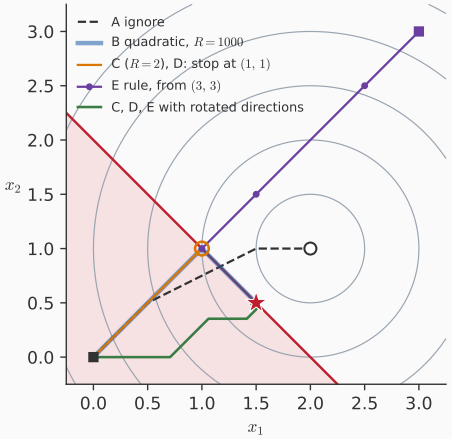
In the course HJ, `menor` ("less") is optional (by default, $a < b$).

The same problem, five treatments

Treatment	What HJ receives	Result (n_F)	Feasible?	Lesson
A ignore	f	(2, 1) (96)	no	the algorithm does not see g
B quadratic	$f + R\,v^2$, $R = 1000$	(1.500, 0.500), $v = 5 \cdot 10^{-4}$ (644)	no (almost)	approaches from outside; large R is costly
C exact	$f + R\,v$, $R = 2$	(1, 1) (91)	yes	$\mathbf{x}^*$ minimizes F_R, but there is a kink
D extreme barrier	f, or $+\infty$ without evaluating f	(1, 1) (91)	yes	never leaves X; needs $\mathbf{x}^{(0)} \in X$
E rule	comparisons of (v, f)	(1, 1) (91); from (3, 3): (1, 1) (96)	yes	no sum; starts from outside
C, D, E rotated	the same; directions $Q\mathbf{e}_j$	$\mathbf{x}^* = (1.5, 0.5)$ (208)	yes	the directions matter

B and C change the function; D refuses points; E changes the comparison. The algorithm is always the same.

The paths



- In X, all of them see the same f: from (0, 0), the paths coincide up to the boundary.
- There they split: A crosses it; B slides along it from outside; C and D stop at (1, 1).
- E, from (3, 3), first reduces the violation; once in X, it compares like D.
- With the rotated directions, the path follows the boundary up to $\mathbf{x}^*$.

How to choose

explicit and cheap $g \to$ C or E (or B with increasing R, 4.3.1).
expensive f, or undefined outside $X \to$ D. Hidden constraint (no v) $\to$ D.

On the computer: the five treatments in MATLAB and Python

MATLAB

```
f = @(x) (x(1) - 2)^2 + (x(2) - 1)^2;
g = @(x) 2 - x(1) - x(2);                % g(x) >= 0
v = @(x) max(0, -g(x));                  % violation
FA = f;                                  % A: ignore
FB = @(x) f(x) + R*v(x)^2;               % B: quadratic
FC = @(x) f(x) + R*v(x);                 % C: exact
FD = @(x) ExtremeBarrier(f, g, x);       % D: barrier
FE = @(x) [v(x), f(x)];                  % E: the pair
menor = @(a, b) a(1) < b(1) || ...
          (a(1) == b(1) && a(2) < b(2));

x = HookeJeeves(FD, [0 0], 2, 0.5, 1e-6, ...
                [], [], [], '1961');
x = HookeJeeves(FE, [0 0], 2, 0.5, 1e-6, ...
                [], false, menor, '1961');
```

Python

```
f = lambda x: (x[0] - 2)**2 + (x[1] - 1)**2
g = lambda x: 2 - x[0] - x[1]            # g(x) >= 0
v = lambda x: max(0.0, -g(x))            # violation
FA = f                                   # A: ignore
FB = lambda x: f(x) + R * v(x)**2        # B: quadratic
FC = lambda x: f(x) + R * v(x)           # C: exact
FD = lambda x: extreme_barrier(f, g, x)  # D
FE = lambda x: (v(x), f(x))              # E: the pair
menor = lambda a, b: a[0] < b[0] or \
          (a[0] == b[0] and a[1] < b[1])

r = hooke_jeeves(FD, [0, 0], 2, 0.5, 1e-6,
                 variante="1961")
r = hooke_jeeves(FE, [0, 0], 2, 0.5, 1e-6,
                 menor=menor, variante="1961")
```

The full script (table, v_R, hidden constraint, start at (3, 3), stall, rotated directions) is in the course companion code, with Colab.

KEY TAKEAWAYS — 4.3.3

1. An unconstrained method sees only numbers (or comparisons): constraints enter via an outer layer.
2. Penalizing (B, C) changes the function: quadratic approaches from outside, ill-conditioned; exact makes $\mathbf{x}^*$ a local minimizer for finite $R > \lambda^*$ (under assumptions), but the algorithm may miss it.
3. Refusing (D) keeps the iterates feasible if one starts from a feasible point; of the strategies here, it is the only one needing no violation measure.
4. Comparing (E) needs no R and no sums, and starts from infeasible points.
5. With nonsmooth functions or barriers, the method's directions decide whether $\mathbf{x}^*$ is reached.

Bridge: GLODS (5.1), DMS (6.5): extreme barrier; GAs (5.3): penalty/rejection; NSGA-II (6.6): feasibility rule.

Beyond the course: the progressive barrier

Between D and E: it accepts infeasible points whose violation is below a threshold that decreases along the iterations, and refuses the others, like D (Audet and Dennis, 2009; MADS/NOMAD).

OPTIMIZATION IN PRACTICE — Chapter 4 on a real problem

Turbine layout of a wind farm (IDMEC, M4WIND project)

Decision the coordinates (x_i, y_i) of each of the N turbines.

Objective the annual energy produced, net of wake losses.

Constraints minimum distance between turbines — $g_{pq} = \|(x_p, y_p) - (x_q, y_q)\| - d_{\min} \geq 0$, one per pair: $J = N(N-1)/2$ inequalities ($N = 30$: 435); site boundary and exclusion zones (geometric constraints on each turbine).

What changes vs. the textbook f is multimodal and has no reliable derivatives; KKT by hand (2^J cases) is unthinkable. The constraints typically enter by penalty (4.3.1), by extreme barrier/repair or by the feasibility rule (4.3.3, 6.6), within a method from Ch. 5.

The information we have: values of f (expensive) and *geometric* constraints that are cheap to check. This asymmetry — expensive f, cheap g — decides how constraints are handled in a real problem (with D, f is not even evaluated at an infeasible point).

Summary table — Chapter 4

What information do we have about f and the constraints? What does it cost to obtain? What is guaranteed?

Method	Information	How it is solved / cost	Guarantee	Main limitation
Lagrange (4.1)	∇f, ∇h_ℓ analytical	by hand: solve $n+K$ equations	necessary under independence of the ∇h_ℓ	only candidates; nonlinear system
KKT (4.2)	∇f, ∇g_j, ∇h_ℓ	by hand: up to 2^J cases (KKT is not an algorithm)	necessary under LICQ; sufficient if convex	exponential enumeration by hand
Exterior penalty (4.3.1)	f, g_j, h_ℓ (+ gradients, if used internally)	$\sum_t n_f$ of the inner minimizations	$\mathbf{x}_R \to \mathbf{x}^*$ as $R \to \infty$ (under assumptions†)	$\kappa \sim R$; slightly infeasible solution
Log barrier (4.3.2)	f, g_j; interior point	idem, + Phase I	$\mathbf{x}_R \to \mathbf{x}^*$ as $R \to 0$ (under assumptions†); $\lambda_j = R/g_j$	only inequalities; $\kappa \sim 1/R$
In practice (4.3.3)	f, g_j or just "failed"	one minimization	C: local exactness if $R > \lambda^*$ (under assumptions); D, E: depends on the method	the directions

† f, g_j (h_ℓ) continuous; $\mathbf{x}_R$ global minimizers of P, with ($\mathbf{x}_R$) bounded; $\mathbf{x}^*$ unique (without uniqueness: every limit point is a global minimum); for the barrier, also X = closure of the interior. For study. In class: the next two pages.

KEY TAKEAWAYS — Chapter 4

1. Constraints change the directions in which we can improve f.
2. The multipliers tell which constraints "count" and what they are worth.
3. **CHARACTERIZE** (4.1–4.2): Lagrange ($h = 0$: $\nabla f + \sum \lambda_\ell \nabla h_\ell = \mathbf{0}$) and KKT ($g \geq 0$: $\lambda \geq 0$, $ug = 0$) use derivatives $\rightarrow$ first-order conditions $\rightarrow$ candidates; global if convex.
4. **COMPUTE** (4.3): exterior ($R \uparrow \infty$, $\mathbf{x}_R \rightarrow \mathbf{x}^*$ from outside) and interior ($R \downarrow 0$, from inside) use Ch. 3 repeatedly $\rightarrow$ cost = sum of the inner minimizations $\rightarrow$ convergence under assumptions.
5. Turning the constrained problem into unconstrained problems has a price: conditioning.
6. **IN PRACTICE** (4.3.3): penalize, refuse or compare — the algorithm is the same.

Next (Ch. 5): these methods give local minima. What if there are several basins?

References and resources

References Full list: *Course bibliography*, at the end of the course PDF.

- Nocedal, J., Wright, S. J., *Numerical Optimization*, 2nd ed., Springer, 2006 — Sec. 17.2 (exact penalty, Thm. 17.3).
- Deb, K., *An efficient constraint handling method for genetic algorithms*, Computer Methods in Applied Mechanics and Engineering 186(2–4):311–338, 2000 — feasibility rule.
- Lewis, R. M., Torczon, V., *Pattern search methods for linearly constrained minimization*, SIAM J. Optim. 10(3):917–941, 2000.
- Audet, C., Dennis, J. E., Jr., *A progressive barrier for derivative-free nonlinear programming*, SIAM J. Optim. 20(1):445–472, 2009.
- Le Digabel, S., Wild, S. M., *A taxonomy of constraints in black-box simulation-based optimization*, Optimization and Engineering, 2023 (doi:10.1007/s11081-023-09839-3).

Resources

- Companion code: `ex04_3_3_constraint_handling`, `ExtremeBarrier`; `HookeJeeves` (3.2.5) with optional `menor` and the `'1961'` variant.
- MATLAB: `patternsearch` and `ga` accept constraints. NOMAD: progressive barrier.